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Jack, The Lionheart

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AUTHOR'S NOTE

Dedicated to my brother.

CHARACTERS

David Richardson: 20 Years- Old, Older Brother of Jack, Star football player

Jack Richardson: 15 Years- Old, Overweight, Angry, Suffers from a severe form of Autism

David's Dad: 55 Years- Old

SETTING

Blank Stage

TIME

Present Day

Jack, The Lionheart

SCENE 1

DAVID RICHARDSON looks at a photograph. He smiles then frowns. He sets the photograph down.

David: You know, everyone has that one thing they hate, it could be anything really- Spiders, NASCAR, politics, Sally Marsh after she rejects your invitation to homecoming publicly. It could be anything. For me, it's small talk. I absolutely hate it. Not because I hate people... though there is a very small number of people I'd like to spend more than 5 minutes with, but it's just so awkward. You know? I know it's the common thing to do, but people never know when they're going to hit a topic that you just don't want to talk about. I'm sure everyone has something that the second someone mentions it you quickly, switch the topic to, "so how's that weather today? It's just so... weather-y..." People will ask about the usual. Your likes, your dislikes, where you go to school, what you want to do with your life, your hobbies, your family... your family… that's when I talk about the weather. *(He looks at the photograph again. He takes a breath then sets it down).*

People will ask about my family and I always end up lying. They'll ask if I have any brothers or sisters... it's just easier to tell them no, then to explain to them the whole situation. The situation about my brother. Sometimes it's easier to lie than to tell truth especially if you've never told the full truth to anyone before. I've always wanted to, but never have. I know they'll look at me differently and someone will get over dramatic about what happened- but damn it, I'm tired of talking about the weather.

It's funny; I always wanted someone to play with. When I was just 2 and learning how to talk, I begged my parents to give me a brother. They told me that they couldn't just give me a brother. It wasn't that easy. I then asked where babies came from. They began to stutter and started talking sports- that was their topic changer. In a few months my mom was pregnant. I personally thought there was a monster growing inside my mom's belly. I was terrified and would run whenever she would enter the room, so her monster belly wouldn't eat me. To comfort me, my mom pulled me up close to her and she said, "Sweetie, this will be your brother. We're going to name him Jack. In two months he'll be born. You two will love each other. We're going to be a big happy family." My mom held me tight, so tight, I didn't think she'd ever let go.

Two months later, when I was 3, my brother Jack was born. I was excited to have a brother though I thought he looked like a lizard because he was all red and scaly. New born babies aren't cute, they're ugly, but you just can't tell that to a woman who just went through 36 hours of labor that her child looks like a lizard... I guess it's understandable why she was mad at me, but her anger didn't matter. I was just so excited to have a brother. It was going to be life changing. I'd have someone to play with all the time. When he was old enough to walk, I called him Jack, the Lionheart. You know after Richard the Lion Heart. My mother was a history teacher, and when we were young, instead of watching cartoons she'd put on history documentaries. By the time I was 5 I could tell you anything you wanted to know about every communist dictatorship. But, like I said, Jack was Richard The LionHeart, my dog was his faithful stead Mao Ze-dog, and I of course was Genghis Khan. Together we would fight dragons, save the princess, and if we had time conquer all of China. That was a typical day for us. (*He pantomimes fighting with a sword)* It was fun.

Jack had normal development, up until around 18 months all of a sudden things he could do he wouldn't do anymore... like he forgot how to brush his teeth, he would stop making noise all together, and he would throw huge temper tantrums... After a few months of this my parents took him to a doctor... and more doctors. After a while we diagnosed with a unique form Autism Spectrum Disorder. This was in the 90's before, Autism really had become prevalent. I had no idea what it meant... When I was told meant he had a super power that made it easier to fight all those dragons. He's "super power" ended up to be much worse. Now normal cases of Autism really aren't that bad, usually it just means a lack of understanding of social cues, repetitive behavior and a few other minor characteristics. Sometimes you may not even know if someone has it- They could just be the awkward kid. My brother's case was the most severe anyone had ever seen. They didn't know if he would ever talk normally... and he never did. I never had a normal conversation with him. I had conversations with him, but they were imaginary, just like our adventures.

As we grew older my brother and I would slay fewer dragons. I mean... he never really did any slaying, but I'd pretend he would be. Jack the Lionheart, with his super power of autism, could slay any dragon! It was the only way I could keep him normal in my head. I mean not everyone has a brother who can slay dragons and have the superpower of autism... He did all sorts of weird things which I found hilarious. He didn't like the feeling of clothes, so he'd run around naked. One time my dad had a dinner party for people at his work. Everyone was dressed fancy. My brother ran into the room completely naked. My parents were horrified especially when my brother ran over to my dad's boss and ate his cake. At least he kept life interesting. *(Pause)*

Soon Jack and I stopped out adventures altogether. I found a new love- football. I would play all the time. I wanted to be the quarterback for my high school football team. Not to brag, I was pretty good. Even when I was just in middle school, high schools all over were trying to get me

to play on their team. My mom would take me to all the schools no matter how far. She was there for every practice. She always found time for me. It was one of the most exciting times of my life. She was amazing. Everything you could want in a mother. It looked like my life was heading in the right direction. That was when my life began to change course and I began to talk about the weather much more.

Puberty is different for everyone. For me, it meant that I no longer had any control over my body and would knock things over all the time. It also meant that my voice would crack every time I talked to a girl. When I asked Sally Marsh to the homecoming dance, I said “Sally will you go to home *(voice crack)* coming with me?” It wasn’t my smoothest moment.

For my brother it was difficult. It's hard enough being normal going through puberty... but for someone with Autism, who can barely understand the world to begin with, he began to react violently. In psychology there are these terms: the Id, Ego and Superego. The super ego is what society thinks you should act. The Id is how your natural instincts. Your ego is balance between the two. The best way to describe it is that my brother was all Id. He couldn’t comprehend what society thought, so he had no ego or super ego. His mind couldn’t understand when something didn’t feel right, or when he didn’t get something he wanted. This caused him to go into fits where he would hit and attack anyone around him... including himself. I remember one morning, my dad was away for the weekend and I was sleeping. I heard this scream, I woke up. It was my mom. She shouted, “David, I need help.” I ran into the room. It was my brother trying to hit her. I rushed over and put him in a headlock, “Jack, stop! This is not okay. This is now how we treat out family.” His “episodes” were fine in the beginning, he was small, but after he grew to be 6 feet weighed 300 pounds, it became more challenging to handle.

My brother loved junk food. He would always want to eat and we couldn't tell him no because... he'd get angry and hit us. Maybe we were weak. I don't know, but there's only so many times that your brother can attack you, so eventually you just learn to let it go. There are only so many times your son can hurt you. It was hard on my parents, I wanted to help them, but they said "it was their problem" they "created" the monster and to let them deal with it. There's only so many time you can deal with the sound of waking up to your mom screaming because she's being attacked by your brother and only so many times you can deal with your son. My mom wanted to put him in a home, but I dad said no to the idea. He wanted to believe he could be a good father, no matter the circumstances. He said he’d never give up on Jack. My mom and dad would argue about it all the time. I remember I was getting ready to leave for practice and I heard them yelling. My mom said, “It’s not safe for anyone with him here. He can hurt us, David and himself.” My dad said “Damn it, he’s our son we will take care of him. We can do this.” “Bill, we can’t do this any longer.” “Do it for Jack.” “I can’t do this any longer.” “Find a way” “You always have to get your way, don’t you Bill?” My mom had a tear roll down her face, and she saw me in the corner. “Oh David, your dad and I were just discussing sports. Are you ready for

practice? I put your Gatorade in the car already" The whole car ride we were silent. I was excited because the next day was my birthday. *(Pause)*

The next morning my mom came into my room really early. She had a sad look on her face. She came in with a present. She looked me in the eye and said, " David... you know I love you right?" and I said "Yes of course, I love you too" "Well, sometimes we have to do what's best for us, do you understand?" I had no idea what she meant, but I didn't want to disagree with her, so I said "Sure." She handed me my gift, it was brand new cleats. I had been asking for these cleats for years and they were super expensive. I hugged her and she kissed me on the cheek. She left crying. I had no idea why. I was very confused. But I understood later.

That was the last time I saw my mom. It was just too much for her to deal with my brother. She left. Last I heard she just moved in with a nice new man and a "better family" so that's good. Good for her .My dad held strong though. He was making good money, but he knew it was best to make sure that we were financially stable. He picked up a second job. He pulled me aside one day and said
"Son, I'm going to need you to step up. I know you have a lot on your plate, but you need to be here after school to watch brother."
So I did. I didn't see friends, and I didn't do anything extracurricular, I even quit football. The one thing that made me so happy. Every day after school I'd get my brother off the bus and I'd watch him until my dad came home late at night. I did it for my dad. Family was always so important to me; I'd do anything for them.

At first it was fine; I tried really hard to teach him things. I spent the better part of one summer teaching him how to swim. Which I was able to. Then I tried a more difficult task, to teach him how to talk. I started with something simple... Jack say, I love you.
He said, "Pizza." The only words my brother would ever say were food. I mean it was only a few words he knew and he always said them wrong. I still tried. Jack say I love you. *(Silence)* Jack... say I love you! (*Silence*) Jack do you love me? Say I love you. *(Silence)* "Damn it Jack." *(Pause)* Jack, I know somewhere in that brain of yours, you love me right? Jack, do you love me? I can't just give up my life for you if you don't love me back. *(Jack starts crying)* Jack, you don't need to cry, I'll get you some food. I'll get you pizza, your favorite. *(Walks over to the counter)* Here Jack, here's some left over pizza. Here you go. *(He feeds Jack the pizza, Jack bites his fingers)* Ouch, damn it. You don't love me, do you? If you did you wouldn't do this to me. Here, take your damn pizza.

It got worse. Teachers at school thought my dad was abusing me from all the bruises I had. I could have told them about Jack, but I didn't want anyone to know. I wanted to keep strong. I didn't want to look weak. I wanted to be strong like my dad. We took him to a specialist. It cost only 400$ an hour and all she did was give medication. Valium. If he got aggressive give him

Valium. That's what she told us to do. Every time he got aggressive I gave it to him. After taking it a few times brother realized that he liked the feeling the pills gave him. Even if he was having an episode, he still would take it. He viewed it like candy. We kept it locked away, so he couldn't get it.

When things got tough I'd try to think of the good times. Like when we were slaying dragons and conquering China, "Jack, the Lionheart and me Genghis Khan!" But it got hard... a little too hard. I know I told my dad I would be there for the family, but I began to understand why mom left. One day he came home and I was exhausted. I walked up to him. "Dad, I can't do this anymore." "Son I know it's hard, but you can do this. We need this money. It'll be fine. "I understand financial security, but Dad, what about emotional security? What about the security of your own son? Do these bruises look secure to you? How about me giving up everything, dad? How about letting mom leave?" "What did you just say to me?" "Dad, she left because of you." "No, she left because she didn't want to try hard enough for this family. Now go to bed. Be strong David, for the sake of this family."

As far as I was concerned, I had no family. That's one of the reasons I loved football, I was a part of a team. I suddenly would have a family of dozens. There were hundreds of fans cheering for me. I wasn't alone… but the cheering stopped. The football family disappeared. My real family was broken. I tried to keep strong. I pretended, like so many people do, that I was fine! I could do this! Some people do fine being alone, but not me. I guess sometimes we're not as strong as we think we are.

It was a Wednesday afternoon. I had just failed a test because I had no time to study because I was hiding from him the day before. I was in a bad mood... but so was he. He came into the house and hit me. Then he bit me. I ran off. Then he bit himself. He was screaming at the top of his lungs. I had never hit Jack. I was always good, but this was getting to be too much. I tried to remember, Jack, the Lion heart and our adventures... the good times... but then I remembered that all those good times were made up. I was tired of hiding from him. I walked to him and he hit me... and hit me... but this is what I wanted. I wanted to excuse to fight back. And I fought. I slapped him across the face. I punched him. I punched. His nose started bleeding. He kept crying.

"Jack, do you think it's fun? Having to be hit all the time. You keep hitting your own damn brother. I know you don't understand, but damn it I'm your brother, doesn't that mean anything to you? No of course it doesn't. I gave up everything, my friends, football and this is what I get in return? A house with no mom, and no father who is there. It's all because of you!" I walked over and got the Valium... I looked at it. I mean... if this could calm him down for a little while, why not a long time? Why not forever? No more fear of being hit by him. I gave him one dose. My brother at least understood that the medication would make him feel better, so he always took it

willingly. I gave him a second dose... and third... and fourth... The rest of the bottle. My brother relaxed and walked to another room.

After my brother got violent he would always do this one thing; the one thing my brother would do that would convince me that he had some emotion was after he would get aggressive he would come over and try to apologize. Obviously he wouldn't say anything, but he'd hold your hand as if he knew he did a bad thing. He walked over to me and held my hand. I just sobbed. "I'm sorry Jack... I love you" and for the first time ever he said.

Jack: I love you.

David: Those were the last words he ever said. In that moment, I looked into his eyes. In that moment I realized, that all Jack wanted was what we all wanted. To be understood. He couldn't communicate like the rest of us. That made him angry. He just wanted to understand what was going on. In that moment, I realized I was a horrible brother.

When the cops came I told them that I had given him one dose and I forgot to close the lid. I told them I had taken a nap. And during that nap he must have taken the rest. I explained how when he didn't feel well he would take the pills because he knew it would make him feel better. He just must have taken too much, not knowing what it would do to him. Now normally I'd probably get in a lot of trouble for something like this or at least questioned, but because he was so disabled, they didn't really care. Authority figures tend to ignore the "weird" ones.

No one really knows what happens. Not even my dad. I thought my brother was a monster. But really who is the monster? Maybe, I'm just like my mom, doing what's best for me. Or maybe I'm like my dad and I'll ignore when people hurt, when I hurt. I haven't talked to either of them in a while. We all just kind have kept our distance since the incident. I'm living my own life now. I made it onto my college football team. It looks like I'll start varsity next year. Although in the end, I don't know if it really matters. I personally think, we only have hobbies to distract us from what hurts.

If I told people this, they wouldn't believe me. Everyone thinks I'm such a happy person. That's the problem with happy people; no one really knows what they're hiding inside. Ever notice how comedians, always seem to have the most depressing lives? I think it's the same for people who smile a lot. We just all have different ways of coping. I'll keep smiling, so no one knows about Jack. This is why I hate small talk. No one ever really wants to know the true answer. They just want words to drown out the silence, so when people ask about my family. It's just a lot easier to lie. I tell them that, I am an only child. That way, they'll have to never know about Jack, the Lionheart. *(Looks to the sky)* Jack, I hope the weather is good up there.

END OF PLAY